

A Grammar of Weirding Partycrashes the World!

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Weird ages have their weird grammars. Few ages were weirder than the Mongol one, whose revolution partycrashed the known world order and nightmared (with the Black Death) a new pan-Afro-Eurasian ecumene into being. Naturally, its grammars were exceptionally weird too—and none more so than Sakkākī's *Book of the Complete*, which partycrashes the cosmic order itself to cultivate the total transhuman as Trickster and Imp of Fate.¹

In its Black Mirror may be scried the omni-tumults of its time. Languages, cultures, creeds and species jostle chaotically and half-sensically between heaven and earth; plants and animals and minerals and devils and planets and angels are dangerous allies in the struggle for psychophysical survival amidst treacherous cosmopolitics. Like a shaman, our Diecaster himself melts into the deceitful shadows of history. Yet his very loud and Tricky and unkempt Helleno-Irano-Indo-Judeo-Islamic book is all things to all men, human or otherwise (especially *otherwise*). An alarmingly/amusingly misshapen Frankenstein's monster arriving fake (?) drunk to the Mongol total-warlord orgy, this slippery, promiscuously pan-traditional text evoked that “stately pleasure-dome” so craftily and viscerally as to become an enduring classic of the *grimoire-as-cosmic-grammar* genre throughout the vast post-Mongol Persianate world. It remains to this day a juicy emblem of magic as World-Weirding and Change.

Thus Ibn Manẓūr's (d. ca. 1312) equally classically Mongol-era definition of *siḥr* in strictly grammatical terms: “changing a thing into other than its proper state” (*ṣarf al-shay' 'an ḥaqīqati-hi ilā ghayri-hi*)—which is to say, applied cosmic morphology (*'ilm al-ṣarf*).² Thus Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī's (d. 1274) revolutionary Persian recentering of Aristotelian-Avicennan poetics on weirdness

¹ My partycrashing theme is of course in homage to Emily Selove, one of the weirdest wordsmiths on the planet, and uniquely able to pull off this painfully literally Sakkākian Trick. Like another sounding of Moby-Dick, her obscenely Hermetic, crypto-Platonic oeuvre has done much to obsess me too with the dangerously underwater and hence necessarily drunken search for the Word as Cosmic Magic. See e.g. her *Hikāyat Abī al-Qāsim: A Literary Banquet* (Edinburgh, 2016), especially ch. 5: ‘The Cosmic Crasher’; idem, *The Donkey King: Asinine Symbolism in Ancient and Medieval Magic* (Cambridge, 2023).

² *Lisān al-'Arab*, s.v. Cf. E. Selove, ‘Magic as Poetry, Poetry as Magic: A Fragment of Arabic Spells’ *Magic, Ritual and Witchcraft* 15 (1) (2020), pp. 33-57; and Ibn Turka's (d. 1432) lettrist analysis of the science in his *R. dar ma'nī-yi khavāṣṣ-i 'ilm-i ṣarf*, edited and translated in M. Melvin-Koushki, *Persian Pythagoreanism and Imperial Occultism: The Lettrist Treatises of Ibn Turka* (Leiden, forthcoming).

(*gharābat*) and wonder (*taʿajjub*) and pleasure (*iltizāz*) to make language the ultimate psychophysical technology and tool of universal empire.³ And thus the epochal florescence of the occult sciences—literally the “sciences of weirding” (*ʿulūm-i gharība*)—that did much to define post-Mongol Persianate societies, poetically and scientifically obsessed with reading and writing the world as a mathematico-linguistic Riddle, whose solution is the endlessly ambiguous Hermetic marriage of all celestial and terrestrial opposites.⁴

The sewn-together book you hold in your hands—the first of our own New Mongol Age to remarry Sakkākī the boring grammarian to Sakkākī the spicy grimoirist and shaman—is a weirding one too. It serves as a companion Black Mirror both to the shapeshifty past and to the colonialist-Orientalist specters that still haunt modern scholarship on all things Islamic, with pathologically dissociative results. Sakkākī the grammarian may be safely acknowledged as seminal—by disparaging him as painfully dry; Sakkākī the magician must be passed over in silence as embarrassingly seedy.⁵

Such bipolar patronizing of the unfashionable Oriental dead is only possible through the betrayal of basic philology: even the bare titles of Sakkākī’s two watershed books read together give us the code to riddling the man and his watershed age. Admittedly, they are on first blush hilariously grandiose. Can a crusty Arabic grammar by a nonscholar Persophone craftsman really be *The Key to All Human Knowledge*? More preposterously, can his exceptionally motley, stylistically defective, textually unstable and clearly incomplete Arabic grimoire really be *The Comprehensive Book for Making the Complete and Perfected Human*?⁶

³ See M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘Naṣīr al-Dīn Ṭūsī, *Asās al-iqtibās*’ in D. Gutas and B. Gründler (eds), *The Complete Poetics* (Leiden, forthcoming). Here mimesis (*muḥākāt*) as the means of telling (*ḥikāya*) is the engine of all pleasurable weirding; cf. again Selove, *Ḥikāyat Abī al-Qāsim*. It must be emphasized that Ṭūsī—not coincidentally also master occult-scientist to both the Khwarazmshahs and the Mongols—was the first to rigorously philosophically frame *weird poetics* within the Aristotelian-Avicennan system. For the broader historical and theoretical context see L. Harb, *Arabic Poetics: Aesthetic Experience in Classical Arabic Literature* (Cambridge, 2020); and T. Zadeh, *Wonders and Rarities: The Marvelous Book That Traveled the World and Mapped the Cosmos* (Cambridge, MA, 2023).

⁴ The Arabic word *gharīb* is semantically wonderfully fluid and terminally creatively ambiguous, meaning something like *strange-foreign-alien-odd-difficult-rare-valuable-elite-precious-paranormal-uncanny-fated-synchronic-itous-ominous-portentious-dangerous-traumatic-shocking-amazing-breathtaking-ravishing-enchanting-magical-wondrous* and above all *weird*, in its encompassing, psychedelic Old English sense. See M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘An Islamic Scientific Revolution? Early Modern Occult Science, Cosmic Philology and the Weird,’ in J. Stearns and N. Fancy (eds), special roundtable issue, *History of Science* 61 (2) (2023), pp 166-72. Cf. S. Ahmed, *What Is Islam?: The Importance of Being Islamic* (Princeton, 2016); T. Bauer, *A Culture of Ambiguity: An Alternative History of Islam*, trans. H. Biesterfeldt and T. Tunstall (New York, 2021).

⁵ The seminal/seedy pun is intended—and demonstrates our mage as annoyingly Microcosmic partycrasher of modernity itself. See E. Selove and M. Sanad, ‘The Sorcerer Scholar: Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī between Grammar and Grimoire’ in K. Morimoto and S. Rizvi (eds), *Knowledge and Power in Muslim Societies: Approaches in Intellectual History* (Berlin, 2023), pp. 95-120.

⁶ My multiple translations here of the title *Kitāb al-Shāmil wa-baḥr al-kāmil* are meant as riffs to give a sense of the range of its complementary meanings, especially philosophically and technologically.

Grandiose and preposterous, perhaps. Yet the enduring popularity of these twin manuals across a huge swath of the human species over centuries suggests some truth in the advertising, that ancient and powerful sorcery. To that end, their titles shamelessly play on the classic Platonic-Pythagorean theurgic project—whose contemporary resurgence among philosophers and encyclopedists was demonized by polemicists as the cause of the Mongol conquest itself—to transcend the self and the world by knowing and being and ruling all. Sakkākī’s cosmogrammatical project is thus a classic entry in the perennially modern self-help genre, most recently the preferred vehicle of American New Thought (aka magic) as royal road to self-mastery and sociopolitical power. To really get a taste of how it came across to contemporaries, however, we must look to the ominous triumphs of AI and Silicon Valley transhumanism today: for our tech-broliarch overlords grandiosely yet plausibly promise to Weird the World no less violently or totally than did the Mongols—now through the almighty, all-grokking Algorithm.

As a card-carrying denizen of the OG Uncanny Valley, our Diecaster can be read in hindsight as a Hacker-Disruptor channeling, daringly and fatally, the great disruptions of his age. So I asked AI (Claude 3.5 Sonnet) to help me honor his infamy, and together we hallucinated this limerick:

There once was a mage from Khwarazm
 Whose grammars caused quite the schism
 They treated all text
 Like worlds to be hexed
 And that’s how we got Al-Gorithm!

The Silicon Golem and I do not mean to claim Sakkākī as a lettrist *avant la lettre*. The Pythagorean discipline that is lettrism/kabbalah (*‘ilm-i ḥurūf*) was peculiar to the thirteenth-century Hellenic-Judeo-Islamic Mediterranean zone, and only formally codified as a cosmo-imperial master science in the Persianate world from the fifteenth century onward. Nevertheless, his *Comprehensive Book* and *Key to All the Sciences* together prognosticated the boom in the grimoire-as-cosmic-grammar genre; it would become a mainstay of post-Mongol Persianate cultures, which pursued Platonic-Pythagorean *gnōsis* as imperial, World-Weirding theurgy more comprehensively, systematically, politically and playfully than did any others in the known history of the Greater West.⁷ That our groaner of a limerick riffs on Sakkākī’s status as a native

⁷ This synthesizes my argument in various places; see e.g. M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘Of Islamic Grammatology: Ibn Turka’s Lettrist Metaphysics of Light,’ *al-‘Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 24 (2016), pp. 42-113; idem, ‘How to Rule the World: Occult-Scientific Manuals of the Early Modern Persian Cosmopolis,’ *Journal of Persianate Studies* 11 (2) (2018), pp. 140-54; idem, ‘*Tahqīq* vs. *Taqlīd* in the Renaissances of Western Early Modernity,’ *Philological Encounters* 3 (1-2) (2018), pp. 193-249; idem, ‘Mīr Dāmād’s *On Doffing*: Safavid Philosophy, Ritual Magic and Out-of-Body Experience,’ in O. Mir-Kasimov and M. Terrier (eds), *From the Letter to the Spirit: Studies in Honour of Mohammad Ali Amir-Moezzi* (Turnhout, 2025), 779-818. More generally, see now W. Hanegraaff, *Esotericism in Western Culture: Counter-Normativity and Rejected Knowledge* (London, 2025).

Khwarazmian—whence the English word “algorithm”—therefore makes it a hilariously historically not inaccurate joke.⁸

By the same premodern and modern imperial token, to be a cosmogrammarian is by definition to be a cosmopolitician too: hence his commitment (following Plato) to magic as *psyop*. Then as now, the political need to control bodies by controlling minds through language and image is always paramount. This is why the careers of court mages tend to be unusually mercurial, often beginning famously or mysteriously, fluctuating dramatically, then ending in exile, imprisonment and/or death. It turns out that trafficking in the political atom bomb that is mind-control (*taskhūr-i qulūb*) has never been particularly safe—especially when serving the Mongols. A classically tragic court mage, Sakkākī, all too predictably, died in prison after a jealous rival successfully poisoned the khan’s imagination against him.⁹ Such is the terrifying power of *takhyīl*. This term of art is usually translated as “image-evocation” or “make-believe” by literary historians; but taking seriously poetry’s status as licit sorcery (*sihr ḥalāl*) in a warlord court setting, read through the Islamic Platonic cosmology then becoming ascendant, requires a more uncanny, punchy and violent translation: *poetic voodoo*.¹⁰

Politically irresistibly dangerous, Sakkākian poetic voodoo—*takhyīl* as *taskhūr*—gained so much in vogue over the following centuries that many of its operations became a technological staple of early modern Persianate imperial, bureaucratic and personal life. His *Total Book* was canonized in the fifteenth century as of a pair with its major inspiration and source, Ṭabasī’s (d. 1089) *al-Kitāb al-Shāmīl*. Despite the slight yet significant grammatico-political difference between the two grimoires’ titles (Sakkākī’s, unlike Ṭabasī’s, ambiguously emphasizes both textual extension and transhuman perfection), major encyclopedist-occultist authorities like Kāshifī (d. 1502) referred to them together simply as the *Shāmīlayn*.¹¹ During the same period, the twin cosmogrammatological occult sciences that are astrology and lettrism together became philosophically and politically hegemonic as *Key to All Human Empire and Evolution and Time Itself*. They were accordingly technologically married in new, more powerful forms of talismanry, from tex-

⁸ Specifically, the word is derived through the usual Latin garbling from the origin name of Muḥammad b. Mūsā al-Khwārazmī (d. ca. 850), the famed ‘Abbasid mathematician, astronomer and geographer, who penned an important West-East *zīj*—the cosmos-reading genre that is the basis of Greater Western astrology and hence half of Sakkākī’s cosmos-writing magic. That Claude.ai is named after Claude Lévi-Strauss (d. 2009)—a structuralist as focused on binaries as any lettrist—is also weirdly salient here.

⁹ Thus Laknawī’s nineteenth-century account; the Timurid-Safavid historian Khwāndamīr’s (d. 1535) early sixteenth-century account is more technically specific as to the psychological mechanics (*Ḥabīb al-siyar*, vol. 3, p. 81): ‘Said [his rival]: “Since Sakkākī has the power to create such things, he is capable of sending an army of fire against the king should he wish to imagine (*khayāl*) rulership for himself.” These operative (*mu’aṣṣir*) words moved Chaghatāy Khān to imprison Sakkākī, where he remained for three years, then set out for the Other-world.’

¹⁰ Here I riff on Selove’s ‘The Dream Theory of Translation,’ chapter 13 in this volume.

¹¹ Kāshifī, *Javāhir al-tafsīr*, ed. J. ‘Abbāsī (Tehran, 1379 Sh./2000), pp. 566, 645; see M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘Reading, Then Rewriting, the Cosmic Text: Kāshifī’s *Jewels of Exegesis* and the Timurid Canonization of Tafsir as Magic’ in B. Fudge and W. Halawi (eds), *Esotericism and the Quran* (forthcoming). Specifically, Sakkākī would seem to be playing on the New Persian tendency to drop the first definite article in Arabic compound phrases; that this play was understood to be intentional is indicated by its consistent preservation by later scholars and copyists.

tual to mathematical to architectural, designed to algorithmically control minds and bodies with greater precision and recode the imperial past, present and future. Since the *Complete Book* is not particularly lettrist and only half astrological, however, at least some of its early modern receptions and additions—attributed to Sakkākī’s son Muḥammad—therefore gravitate toward its astromagical operations as Pythagorean-Harranian theurgy, or simply invoke it as a talisman for conjuring Mongol universalist imperialism.



Three sixteenth-century examples tell this story of Sakkākī’s early modern reception with special piquance.¹² The first is *The Stars That Drive All the Sciences* (*Nujūm al-‘ulūm*), a gorgeous, though incomplete, imperial Persian encyclopedia of 53 sciences composed in 1570 by the Twelver Deccan philosopher-king ‘Alī ‘Ādilshāh (r. 1558-79) himself. Even in incomplete form, *The Stars* is by far the most lavishly illustrated book of the early modern Persianate era, to ensure operational accuracy. It is also the most systematically ecumenical marriage of Islamic with Indic occult science produced before the seventeenth century; prefiguring and provoking immediately subsequent Mughal developments, here Persian and Sanskrit are epistemic equals. The title of this summa of sixteenth-century Irano-Indic imperial Star Science—rewritten in astro-lettrist terms—is thus no mere rhetorical flourish: even more than its Safavid, Mughal and Ottoman peers, the *Nujūm* is systematically astrolatrous. System is of course foreign (*gharīb*) to the *Shāmīl*, in sharp contrast to the *Miftāḥ*; yet its sultan-scientist author gives Sakkākī pride of place by means of the Moon. Our Mongol-Khwarazmian grimoire, significantly, begins by initiating the reader into Selenic magic (the first book is *muṣḥaf al-qamar*) as Hermetic psychopomp of Avicennan occult-philosophical practice. Our ‘Ādilshahi encyclopedia canonizes it by prominently featuring one of the most potent and radical Drawing Down the Moon (*taskhīr-i qamar*) operations in Western history—and attributes it to Sakkākī Jr.¹³

Likewise epitomizing the astro-lettrist turn that defines much of post-Mongol imperial science, the second is ‘Abd al-‘Alī Bīrjandī (d. 1526), the most celebrated astrophysicist of the late Timurid and early Safavid era, who was direct heir to the glories that were the Maragha and

¹² Needless to say, very little of the necessary research has been done to date, so my sketch here is strictly rough; but the editions and translations in these volumes will finally allow us to track and map its specific receptions.

¹³ *Nujūm al-‘ulūm*, Dublin, Chester Beatty Library, MS In. 02 (copied 1570), 348 ff., f. 114a-b. The proximate source is almost certainly Muḥammad b. Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī’s *Taskhīrāt*; preserved in 12 Safavid and later manuscript copies, it is an extraction and Persian translation and/or adaptation of planetary, angel, jinn and spirit subjugation operations in the *Shāmīl* (cf. whose original Moon operation at 5:1-2). Despite its outsize importance, the only study of the *The Stars* to date is E. Flatt, *The Courts of the Deccan Sultanates: Living Well in the Persian Cosmopolis* (Cambridge, 2019), ch. 5; see also Zadeh, *Wonders and Rarities*, 278-82. Tellingly, Rāzī’s *Hidden Secret*—speaking of Khwarazmians, he dedicated his grimoire to the Khwārazmshāh—privileges Moon theurgy above all other planetary theurgic modes too, describing its operation at much greater length than any other; see M. Noble, *Philosophising the Occult: Avicennan Psychology and ‘The Hidden Secret’ of Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī* (Berlin, 2021), 270-76. More broadly, see M. Melvin-Koushki, “Selenocentrism and Heliocentrism in Early Modern Persianate Imperial Cultures: ‘Alī versus Jesus, with Hermes Presiding’ *al-Uṣūr al-Wuṣṭā* 33 (2025), forthcoming.

Samarkand Observatories; yet he also produced the most seminal Persian translation of and commentary on Yāfi‘ī’s (d. 1367) *Strung Pearl* (*al-Durr al-naẓīm*), one of the all-time classics of cosmopolitical quranic lettrism. (I take its popularity as another smoking gun in my case for Persian Pythagoreanism as a driver of the Islamic Occult-Scientific Revolution.¹⁴) But of course it gets weirder. One Aḥmad son of al-Ḥājj Muḥammad, a shadowy Timurid-Safavid worthy, thought Bīrjandī’s translation too elite, so in 1520 published a new Persian translation more accessible to the aspiring masses in a classic democratizing move. It too would go on to be quite successful—thanks to its peculiarly Perso-magical family trademark: therein Aḥmad identifies as a *Sakkākī-Ṭabasī*.¹⁵

The third is Kāshifī himself, bestselling Timurid polymath, preacher, Sufi and mage *par excellence*, whose gorgeous yet democratizing Persian works on a galaxy of topics did much to create their respective canons for the sixteenth century and after; he appears to be the first to make Sakkākian magic canonical too, whence its featuring in *The Stars*. In particular, his *Qasimian Secrets* (*Asrār-i Qāsimī*)—that watershed fifteenth-century grimoire whose high Safavid expansion made it a who’s who of early modern Persianate court occulture—cites a *Shāmīl-i akbar* as operational source, clearly referring to Sakkākī’s expansion of Ṭabasī.¹⁶ (As noted, the Naqshbandi “Agent of the Unveiler” in his radically lettrist tafsir refers rather to the two *Shāmīls* as of a piece.) Despite its narrower focus on illusionism (*sīmiyā*) and trickery (*rīmiyā*), moreover, the original *Asrār* not only invokes the *Shāmīl* but explicitly draws on many of its sources in eclectic new ways, thereby helping make possible a map of Mongol-Timurid, Arabic-Persian continuities and evolutions in grimoire-as-cosmic-grammar culture.¹⁷ Kāshifī, in short, a Persianizing neotraditionalist, universalist, astro-lettrist magician, was and is likewise universally received as both a brilliant craftsman and rigorous channeler of the Arabic language and its classics—lending his life’s project a peculiarly Sakkākian vibe.

Both vastly more productive than his infamous predecessor and luckier by half, Ḥusayn Kāshifī died peacefully just before the berserker Qizilbash conquest of Timurid Herat. His son

¹⁴ M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘An Islamic Scientific Revolution?’

¹⁵ Muḥammad Muḥsin Āqā-Buzurg Tihirānī, *Ṭabaqāt al-‘ālam al-shī‘a*, 17 vols. (Beirut, 1430/2009), vol. 7, p. 125. Specifically, he names himself “Aḥmad b. al-Ḥājj Muḥammad Sakkākī Ṭabasī.” The growing association of Sakkākī with lettrism is likewise testified to by a brief *khavāṣṣ-i ḥurūf* text, preserved in three Iranian manuscripts (two Safavid and one Qajar), purporting to be extracted from one of his works; and a brief divine names operational work, preserved in one undated manuscript, attributed to his son (Dirāyatī, *FaNKha*).

¹⁶ The best study of this seminal grimoire to date is M. Subtelny, ‘Kāshifī’s *Asrār-i qāsimī*: A Late Timurid Manual of the Occult Sciences and Its Safavid Afterlife’ in L. Saif, F. Leoni, M. Melvin-Koushki and F. Yahya (eds), *Islamic Occult Sciences in Theory and Practice* (Leiden, 2021), pp. 267–313 (280). Predictably, despite its bestselling status—it survives in over 80 manuscripts in Iran alone and in several Indian lithograph editions—the *Asrār-i Qāsimī* has yet to be critically edited, much less translated. As for Kāshifī’s styling Sakkākī’s grimoire the *Shāmīl-i akbar*: this is the same sixteenth-century canonizing move that gave us the pseudo-Būnian imperial *Greater Sun of Gnoses* (*Shams al-ma‘ārif al-kubrā*) as infamous epitome of lettrist magic to the present, a book even more dangerous and shapeshifty than Sakkākī’s own.

¹⁷ Unlike many earlier authorities, including Sakkākī, Kāshifī cites his Arabic sources diligently and accurately, making his grimoires—long ignored by Orientalists and Europeanists alike for the sin of being both “postclassical” and Persian—exceptionally useful for mapping the history of Islamic occultism more generally.

‘Alī Ṣafī (d. 1533), who succeeded him as preacher in the same city, had no such luck: like another Sakkākī (and presumably Sakkākī Jr.), he did what he could to negotiate his place in the chaotic new Safavid warlord state by means of language as magic.

To that end, in 1522 ‘Alī Ṣafī epitomized, simplified and localized his father’s *Qasimian Secrets* at the demand of the Qizilbash governor of Khurasan as a *Boon for the Khan* (*Tuḥfa-yi khānī*), laser-focused on only those operations fit to a warlord’s needs in fighting and feasting (*razm u bazm*), from terrifying one’s enemies on the battlefield to entertaining and drugging one’s friends during all-night orgies. It had not a little to do with the popularity of the *Asrār*—packed with *Shāmīl*-esque operations—in elite Safavid, Mughal and post-Mughal circles over the next several centuries. Dedicated to a Kirmani shaykh who served for two years as vizier to the same Qizilbash governor, his *Boon for Majd al-Dīn* (*Tuḥfa-yi Majdiyya*) is similarly radically democratizing. But the first grimoire is classically Sakkākian, while the second—an epitome of the author’s *Amulet of Protection from the Trials of Time* (*Ḥirz al-amān min fitan al-zamān*)—is strictly lettrist, and shares Birjandī’s and Sakkākī-Ṭabasī’s devotion to Yāfi‘ī in particular.

The *Amulet of Protection* outstripped its sources to become one of the most iconic neoclassicist Sunni-Shi‘ī Persian manuals of cosmogrammatological science of the early modern era. Yet there ‘Alī Ṣafī seems to despair of his daring project to transform uncouth warlords into philosopher-kings by means of simplified manuals of practical magic. For the first time in the known Western grimoiric tradition, he explicitly proposes a political system we might as well call *occult bureaucracy*: it is now state functionaries, more than than rulers or commoners, who must be trained as astro-lettrist mages to mind-control tyrants as the best path to imperial peace. This simultaneously democratizing and bureaucratizing project finally bore surprising fruit by the turn of the seventeenth century, when scholar-philosopher and philosopher-king entered into such a productive technopolitical alliance as to successfully transform Isfahan, the new Safavid capital, into the world’s first expressly Solomonian-Pythagorean talismanic city, a mathematical machine for creating the Perfect Superhuman. Using the same code competitively, the Taj Maḥal complex—apotheosis of Timurid imperialism—was designed to be a Transhumanizing Computer too.¹⁸



Sirāj al-Dīn Sakkākī, self-made Khwarazmian craftsman turned shaman, eventually failed to mind-control the Mongols for his own salvation. But his *Total Grammar* and *Total Grimoire* together helped define post-Mongol Persianate cosmopolitics—and invent the Deep State as Algorithm.¹⁹

¹⁸ M. Melvin-Koushki, ‘The Occult Court: ‘Alī Ṣafī’s *Boon for the Khan* (1522) as Timurid-Safavid Manual of Boozing and Battling Magic and Marker of Early Modernity,’ in C. Mauder (ed.), *The Religious Cultures of Premodern Islamicate Courts in Transregional Perspective*, special issue of *Al-Masāq* 37 (1) (2025), forthcoming; idem, ‘Mīr Dāmād’s *On Doffing*.’

¹⁹ Cf. geomancy (*‘ilm al-raml*) as another Pythagorean science, Afro-Arabic cognate to the *I Ching*. But unlike that ancient Chinese oracle, it propagated across the Afro-Eurasian ecumene as a whole and thence the western

I'm not saying he should be read only as an algo canary in the tech-bro bitmine. More Platonist than accelerationist, Sakkākī's command lines run not on silicon golems Frankensteined to life but on the terrifyingly unspeakable yet allspeaking evergibbering nature of the cosmos itself. But I do hear his Tricky shade—so completely (if rashly) conjured in these tomes by Selove and her merry gang of philologist partycrashers—laughing maniacally at our New Mongol imperial transhumanist nightmares, and cursing us with cosmic glee: *Welcome once again to the Weirding of the World!*

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